



It's not real. Get over it.

"The problem with realistic games is that just when you start to get immersed, something reminds you that it is, in fact, just a game"

I'M PRETTY TERRIBLE at racing simulators. As I headed on for my billionth date with the wall in an F1 simulator a long time ago, I was chided for loving the *Need for Speed* and *Burnout* series with the childish enthusiasm that I do. To paraphrase, "How could you like that unrealistic crap? You're missing out on the true driving experience!" Protest a bit, and you get this: "It's the closest you're going to come to the real thing!" more often than not accompanied by, "The realistic graphics make it so immersive!" This tripe even extends to fans of FPS games, so don't sit there looking all smug.

The truth is, as games approach realism, the gaming *experience* drifts farther away from it. Today, you get your "true driving experience" sitting in front of a TV with nothing to look at behind you. You can view a car from above (!) and drive it with an analogue controller. Er... which part of that reflects your real-life driving experience? The latest FPS games are no better—accurately-rendered models of real-life weapons, single head-shot kills, ragdoll physics... But look down, and surprise, surprise—you have no feet! The problem with realistic games is that just when you start to get immersed, something reminds you that it is, in fact, just a game.

The latest attempt at realism—highly amusing, methinks—is the introduction of the moral dilemma. In *BioShock*, after you take down the Big Daddy, you can choose to rescue the Little Sister (a wispy, pathetic little girl),

or kill her and harvest her ADAM to upgrade your powers. In role-playing games like *The Witcher*, you have the option to be a goody two-shoes or a vile child of Darkness, and every choice you make "will have its consequences." Don't be fooled—no matter what you do, you'll always be taken to; oh, let's be optimistic—one of three or four possible endings, if not just the one.

Game developers aren't reading this, so it's hardly likely that they'll see the Light. You, on the other hand, can—forsake this fruitless quest for gaming realism and go back to the real reason people play games—to escape reality. The ultimate in immersion—plain old Fun.

That's what I (and millions more) love about the Wii—it's unabashedly unrealistic, and so much fun it scares me. When I played baseball on it, I found myself forgetting to pause the game while I rested—I then realised I'd expected the pitcher to wait for me to be ready. When you forget that it's really bobbing heads you're playing with, *that's* immersion. I try to imagine a world without the Wii, and I'm profoundly disturbed.

The game I'm currently immersed in? It's a classic called *Gish*—you play a ball of tar (tarball! Just a bit of geek humour there...) on a quest to save your girlfriend from a mysterious sewer-infesting captor. Can't go much farther from reality than that, can I?

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